

COMPLETE CHESS LEARNING LIBRARY

The Complete Ruy Lopez

From first principles to theory, structures, and practical mastery

COURSE BOOK

30 focused chapters - model positions - decision rules - retrieval practice

Designed to change what you notice, calculate, remember, and do at the board.

How to Use This Course

ONE CHAPTER, FOUR PASSES

1. Read the position without moving pieces. 2. State your plan and the opponent's counterplay. 3. Study the decision rules. 4. Close the book and reconstruct the position from memory.

RETRIEVAL SCHEDULE

Review the chapter the next day, one week later, and after a game that reaches a similar structure. Retrieval is more valuable than rereading.

BOARD ROUTINE

Opponent's threat - forcing moves - loose pieces - worst piece - central break - best reply - choose and stop.

The course book explains each model position. The separate workbook forces recall, prediction, and self-scoring. Use the book first, then attempt the matching workbook page without looking back.

Engine evaluations are intentionally not the lesson. The aim is to store human decision rules that remain useful when the exact move order changes.

Course Map

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01. Classical Closed Ruy Tabiya



04 - Closed Ruy Lopez

READ THE POSITION

The classical Spanish center remains closed while both sides prepare a timed central break.

PRIMARY PLAN

Support e4, prepare d4, and route Nb1-d2-f1-g3 only when the center permits it.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black challenges e4 with ...Re8 and seeks ...Bf8, ...Na5, or ...d5.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6 8. c3 O-O 9. h3

MEMORY RULE

Closed Ruy: build d4, improve the knight, and watch Black's freeing break.

01. Decision Framework

Classical Closed Ruy Tabiya

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not play d4 before checking ...exd4 and ...Nxe4 geometry.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Closed Ruy: build d4, improve the knight, and watch Black's freeing break.

02. Exchange Variation with O-O



02 - Exchange and Berlin

READ THE POSITION

White gives the bishop pair to damage Black's queenside structure and simplify the center.

PRIMARY PLAN

Attack the e5 and c6 weaknesses while keeping the kingside majority mobile.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black uses the bishop pair, open d-file, and central activity to make the doubled pawns dynamic.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Bxc6 dxc6 5. O-O f6 6. d4 exd4 7. Nxd4

MEMORY RULE

Exchange Spanish: structure is a target only when your pieces can reach it.

02. Decision Framework

Exchange Variation with O-O

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not assume doubled pawns are weak if files and bishops become active.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

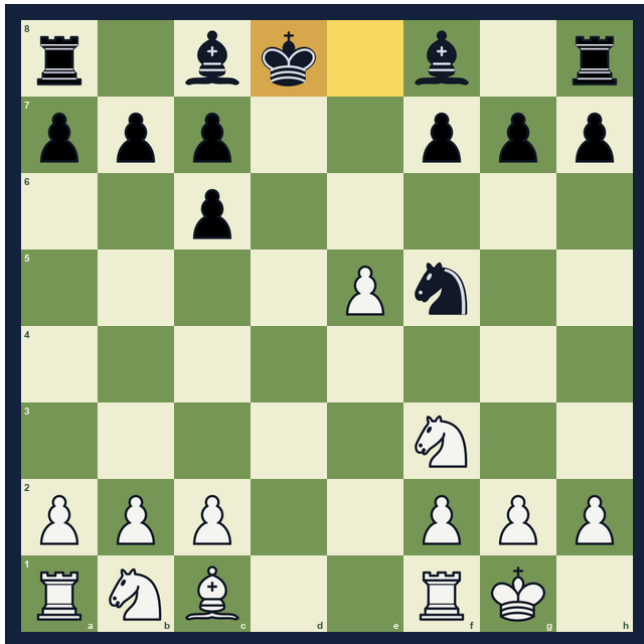
ACTIVE RECALL

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4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Exchange Spanish: structure is a target only when your pieces can reach it.

03. Berlin Endgame



02 - Exchange and Berlin

READ THE POSITION

Queens leave early, but the uncastled black king is often safe and the position remains strategically rich.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use the kingside majority, restrict Black's bishops, and improve the king without rushing.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black relies on the bishop pair, active king, and pressure against White's e5 pawn.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 Nf6 4. O-O Nxe4 5. d4 Nd6 6. Bxc6 dxc6 7. dxe5 Nf5 8. Qxd8+ Kxd8

MEMORY RULE

Berlin endgame: activity and pawn majorities matter more than the missing queens.

03. Decision Framework

Berlin Endgame

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	A nominally exposed king is not a tactical target after the queens disappear.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

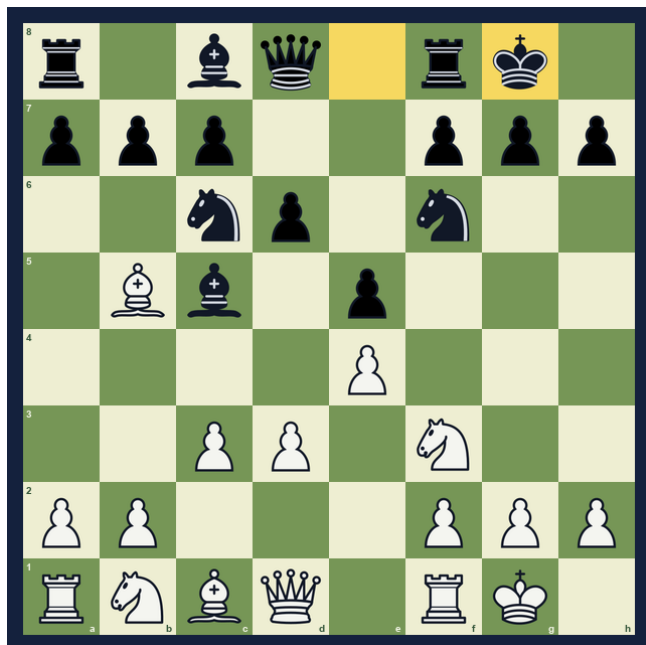
ACTIVE RECALL

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4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Berlin endgame: activity and pawn majorities matter more than the missing queens.

04. Anti-Berlin 4.d3



02 - Exchange and Berlin

READ THE POSITION

White keeps queens and avoids the forcing Berlin endgame while retaining a flexible center.

PRIMARY PLAN

Develop calmly, prepare Re1 and d4, and decide whether Nbd2-f1 or Bxc6 helps.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black equalizes with ...O-O, ...Re8, ...a6, and a well-timed ...d5.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 Nf6 4. d3 Bc5 5. O-O d6 6. c3 O-O

MEMORY RULE

Anti-Berlin: preserve flexibility, but still fight for d4.

04. Decision Framework

Anti-Berlin 4.d3

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not drift in a quiet shell while Black plays ...d5 in one move.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

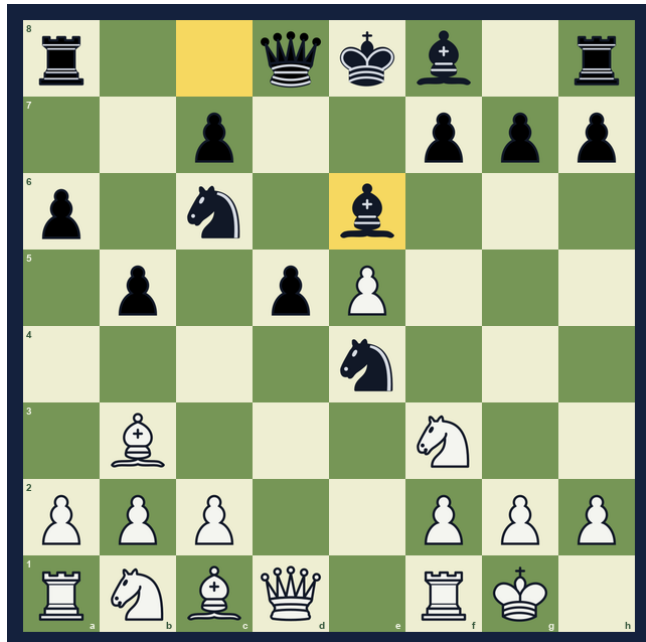
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Anti-Berlin: preserve flexibility, but still fight for d4.

05. Open Ruy Main Line



03 - Open Ruy Lopez

READ THE POSITION

Black takes e4 and opens the center before completing development.

PRIMARY PLAN

Challenge the centralized knight, use c3 and Nbd2, and exploit Black's loose queenside.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black uses the active e4-knight and rapid ...Be6 or ...Bc5 development.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Nxe4 6. d4 b5 7. Bb3 d5 8. dxe5 Be6

MEMORY RULE

Open Ruy: attack the centralized knight without losing the bishop to tempo.

05. Decision Framework

Open Ruy Main Line

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Check every discovered attack on the bishop and every fork on d4 or f2.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Open Ruy: attack the centralized knight without losing the bishop to tempo.

06. Open Ruy Dilworth Attack



03 - Open Ruy Lopez

READ THE POSITION

Black sacrifices or grabs on f2 to create forcing activity against White's king.

PRIMARY PLAN

Finish development, compare king safety, and calculate forcing lines before recovering material.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black uses ...Nxf2, ...f6, and piece pressure for immediate initiative.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Nxe4 6. d4 b5 7. Bb3 d5 8. dxe5 Be6 9. c3 Bc5 10. Nbd2 O-O 11. Bc2 Nxf2

MEMORY RULE

Dilworth: survive the forcing wave, then make the extra material matter.

06. Decision Framework

Open Ruy Dilworth Attack

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Material counting is meaningless until checks and captures stop.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Dilworth: survive the forcing wave, then make the extra material matter.

07. Closed Ruy Chigorin



04 - Closed Ruy Lopez

READ THE POSITION

Black gains queenside space with ...Na5 and ...c5 while White prepares the central break.

PRIMARY PLAN

Complete Nbd2-f1-g3, support d4, and exploit the long-term d5 square.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black expands with ...c5, ...Re8, and ...Bf8 while pressuring the center.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6 8. c3 O-O 9. h3 Na5 10. Bc2 c5 11. d4 Qc7 12. Nbd2

MEMORY RULE

Chigorin: accept queenside space, then fight for d5 and the kingside.

07. Decision Framework

Closed Ruy Chigorin

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not allow ...cxd4 to leave e4 loose and the c2-bishop shut in.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Chigorin: accept queenside space, then fight for d5 and the kingside.

08. Closed Ruy Breyer



04 - Closed Ruy Lopez

READ THE POSITION

Black voluntarily retreats the c6-knight so it can reinforce e5 from d7.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use space to improve every piece and prepare a4 or d5 without forcing matters.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black reroutes ...Nb8-d7, develops ...Bb7, and seeks ...c5 or ...d5.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6 8. c3 O-O 9. h3 Nb8 10. d4 Nbd7

MEMORY RULE

Breyer: space is valuable only when it produces a useful break.

08. Decision Framework

Closed Ruy Breyer

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	The retreat ...Nb8 is not lost time if it removes tactical pressure and improves the structure.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Breyer: space is valuable only when it produces a useful break.

09. Closed Ruy Zaitsev



04 - Closed Ruy Lopez

READ THE POSITION

Black develops the bishop actively and increases pressure on e4 before retreating the other bishop.

PRIMARY PLAN

Reinforce e4, consider a4, and choose between Nf1-g3 and immediate central action.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black threatens ...exd4, ...Na5, and ...d5 while the b7-bishop watches e4.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6 8. c3 O-O 9. h3 Bb7 10. d4 Re8 11. Nbd2 Bf8

MEMORY RULE

Zaitsev: count e4 defenders before beginning the standard knight tour.

09. Decision Framework

Closed Ruy Zaitsev

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Nf1 can lose e4 if central exchanges remove its defenders.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

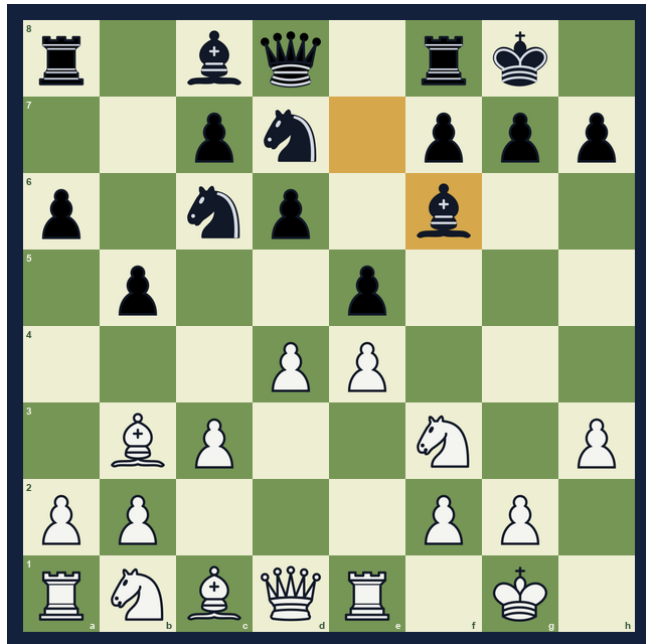
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Zaitsev: count e4 defenders before beginning the standard knight tour.

10. Closed Ruy Karpov System



04 - Closed Ruy Lopez

READ THE POSITION

Black uses ...Nd7 and ...Bf6 to reinforce e5 with a compact but slightly passive setup.

PRIMARY PLAN

Gain queenside space with a4 and consider Na3-c2 before a central break.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black seeks ...Nb6, ...Bb7, and timely simplification of White's center.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6 8. c3 O-O 9. h3 Nd7 10. d4 Bf6

MEMORY RULE

Karpov system: choose the knight route that matches the queenside pressure.

10. Decision Framework

Closed Ruy Karpov System

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Automatic Nbd2 can block the most useful queenside knight route.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

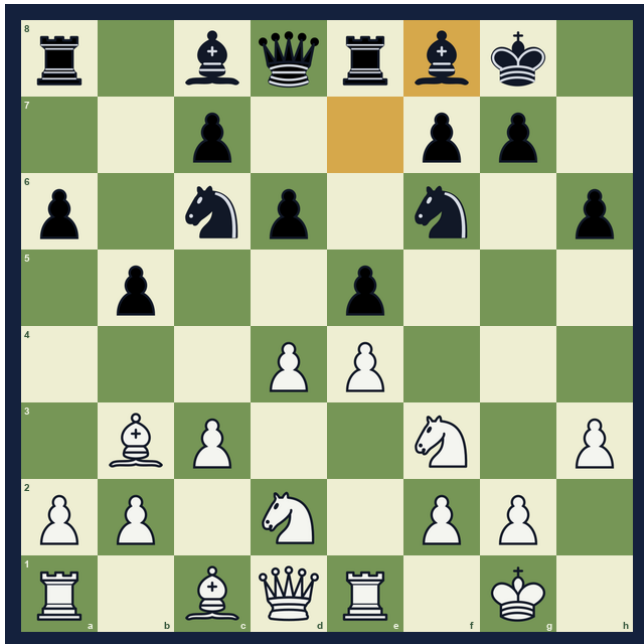
ACTIVE RECALL

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3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Karpov system: choose the knight route that matches the queenside pressure.

11. Closed Ruy Smyslov



04 - Closed Ruy Lopez

READ THE POSITION

Black spends ...h6 to prevent Ng5 and then builds the familiar ...Re8 and ...Bf8 shell.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use the extra tempo to finish the knight maneuver and prepare d5 or a4.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black seeks stability on e5 before expanding or breaking with ...d5.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6 8. c3 O-O 9. h3 h6 10. d4 Re8 11. Nbd2 Bf8

MEMORY RULE

Smyslov: use Black's slow move to complete your central preparation.

11. Decision Framework

Closed Ruy Smyslov

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not attack h6 automatically; the center remains the real battlefield.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Smyslov: use Black's slow move to complete your central preparation.

12. Closed Ruy Kholmov



04 - Closed Ruy Lopez

READ THE POSITION

Black exchanges the Spanish bishop and gives White a semi-open a-file plus doubled b-pawns.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use the a-file and central space; decide whether the b-pawns are weaknesses or useful control.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black seeks central liquidation and activity against the altered queenside.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6 8. c3 O-O 9. h3 Be6 10. d4 Bxb3 11. axb3

MEMORY RULE

Kholmov: evaluate the open a-file before condemning doubled pawns.

12. Decision Framework

Closed Ruy Kholmov

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	A damaged pawn structure can be an attacking asset when it opens a rook file.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Kholmov: evaluate the open a-file before condemning doubled pawns.

13. Marshall Attack



05 - Marshall and Anti-Marshall

READ THE POSITION

Black sacrifices a pawn to accelerate every piece toward White's king.

PRIMARY PLAN

Neutralize activity, return material when useful, and complete development before hunting pawns.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black uses ...Bd6, ...Qh4, and rook lifts to create a sustained attack.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 O-O 8. c3 d5 9. exd5 Nxd5 10. Nxe5 Nxe5 11. Rxe5 c6 12. d4 Bd6

MEMORY RULE

Marshall: extinguish activity first; the extra pawn can wait.

13. Decision Framework

Marshall Attack

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	One careless pawn move can open a mating net even when White is materially ahead.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Marshall: extinguish activity first; the extra pawn can wait.

14. Anti-Marshall 8.a4



05 - Marshall and Anti-Marshall

READ THE POSITION

White prevents the clean Marshall move order and fixes the queenside structure with a4.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use the a-file tension, develop Nbd2-f1, and prepare a central expansion.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black keeps flexible pressure with ...Re8, ...Bf8, and a later ...d5.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 O-O 8. a4 Bb7 9. d3 Re8 10. Nbd2 Bf8

MEMORY RULE

Anti-Marshall a4: fix b5, then decide when the file should open.

14. Decision Framework

Anti-Marshall 8.a4

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Opening the a-file too early can activate Black's rook instead of yours.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Anti-Marshall a4: fix b5, then decide when the file should open.

15. Anti-Marshall 8.h3



05 - Marshall and Anti-Marshall

READ THE POSITION

White removes ...Bg4 ideas and keeps c3 in reserve to discourage a prepared Marshall.

PRIMARY PLAN

Build with d3, Nbd2-f1, and choose c3 only when d4 is ready.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black develops ...Bb7, ...Re8, and may still break with ...d5.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 O-O 8. h3 Bb7 9. d3 Re8

MEMORY RULE

Anti-Marshall h3: keep c3 flexible and make ...d5 earn its freedom.

15. Decision Framework

Anti-Marshall 8.h3

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	A quiet move order does not remove the need to calculate the central break.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Anti-Marshall h3: keep c3 flexible and make ...d5 earn its freedom.

16. Anti-Marshall 8.d3



05 - Marshall and Anti-Marshall

READ THE POSITION

White avoids the gambit and chooses a slow structure without committing c3.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use a4, Nbd2-f1, and a later c3-d4 expansion under favorable conditions.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black gains equality by completing development and arranging ...d5.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 O-O 8. d3 d6 9. a4 Bb7

MEMORY RULE

Anti-Marshall d3: restrain ...d5 before beginning a wing plan.

16. Decision Framework

Anti-Marshall 8.d3

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not play on the wing while the center can open against the king.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Anti-Marshall d3: restrain ...d5 before beginning a wing plan.

17. Archangel with ...Bb7



06 - Archangel Systems

READ THE POSITION

Black develops both bishops actively and delays ...Be7 to increase immediate pressure.

PRIMARY PLAN

Protect e4, finish development, and use a4 or c3 before Black consolidates.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black aims at e4 and f2 while using queenside space for piece activity.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O b5 6. Bb3 Bb7 7. d3 Bc5

MEMORY RULE

Archangel: central security comes before exploiting Black's queenside pawns.

17. Decision Framework

Archangel with ...Bb7

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	The active bishops create tactics whenever e4 becomes loose.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Archangel: central security comes before exploiting Black's queenside pawns.

18. Neo-Archangel with ...Bc5



06 - Archangel Systems

READ THE POSITION

Black places the bishop on c5 immediately and accepts a more exposed queenside.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use c3, a4, and Nbd2 while denying tactics against f2 and e4.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black combines pressure on f2 with ...O-O and ...d5 or ...d6.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O b5 6. Bb3 Bc5 7. d3 d6

MEMORY RULE

Neo-Archangel: respect the c5-bishop, then undermine b5.

18. Decision Framework

Neo-Archangel with ...Bc5

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Bxf7+ is rarely justified unless it wins concrete material or king access.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

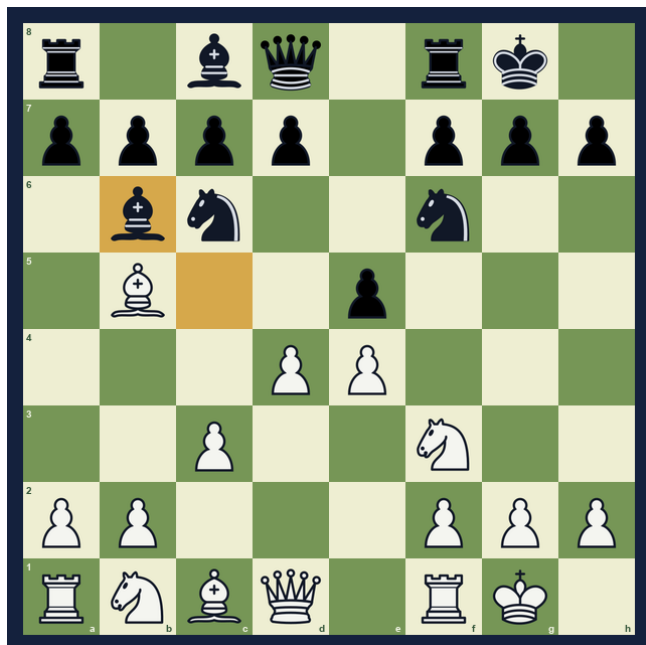
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Neo-Archangel: respect the c5-bishop, then undermine b5.

19. Classical Cordel Defense



07 - Early Black Sidelines

READ THE POSITION

Black develops naturally without ...a6 and invites White to build the center.

PRIMARY PLAN

Play c3 and d4 only after checking the e4 pawn and the bishop retreat tempo.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black attacks the center with ...Nxe4 or ...d5 and keeps rapid development.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 Bc5 4. c3 Nf6 5. O-O O-O 6. d4 Bb6

MEMORY RULE

Cordel: build the center, but count e4 before pushing d4.

19. Decision Framework

Classical Cordel Defense

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	The c3-d4 plan fails if e4 is underdefended after exchanges.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

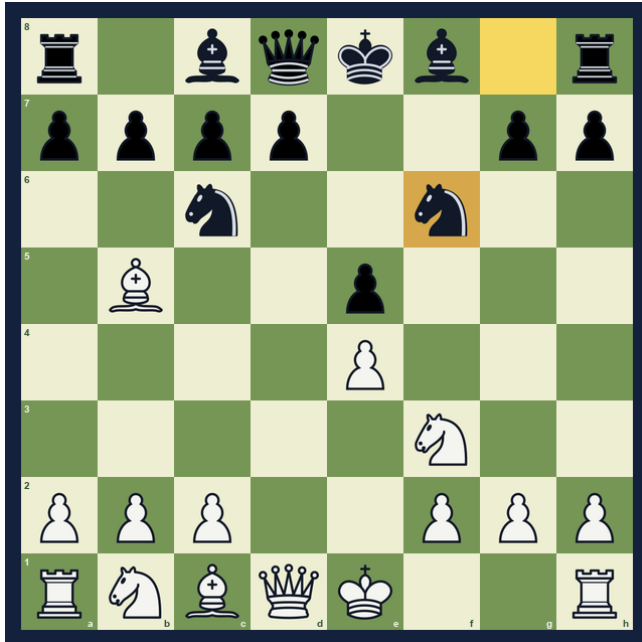
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Cordel: build the center, but count e4 before pushing d4.

20. Schliemann Defense



07 - Early Black Sidelines

READ THE POSITION

Black immediately attacks e4 with the f-pawn and accepts king-side loosening.

PRIMARY PLAN

Keep the center stable, develop, and exploit dark-square weaknesses rather than forcing a refutation.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black wants rapid piece play and pressure on e4 before castling.

REFERENCE LINE 1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 f5 4. d3 fxe4 5. dxe4 Nf6

MEMORY RULE

Schliemann: meet the pawn break with development, not greed.

20. Decision Framework

Schliemann Defense

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Opening the f-file can make careless queen checks rebound against White.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

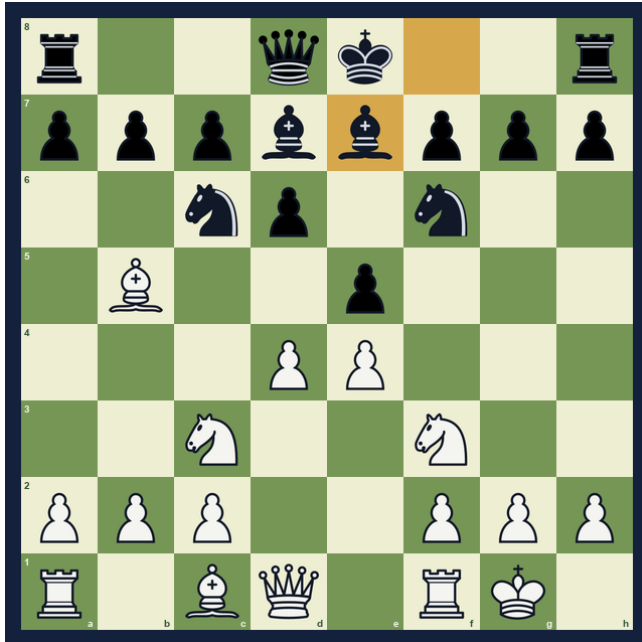
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Schliemann: meet the pawn break with development, not greed.

21. Steinitz Defense



07 - Early Black Sidelines

READ THE POSITION

Black defends e5 solidly but restricts the dark-squared bishop.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use d4, maintain space, and prevent the freeing ...f5 or ...d5 break.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black aims to complete development and challenge the center later.

REFERENCE LINE 1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 d6 4. d4 Bd7 5. Nc3 Nf6 6. O-O Be7

MEMORY RULE

Steinitz: use space to restrict a break, not to collect more space blindly.

21. Decision Framework

Steinitz Defense

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Overextension makes the space advantage a target.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Steinitz: use space to restrict a break, not to collect more space blindly.

22. Deferred Steinitz



07 - Early Black Sidelines

READ THE POSITION

Black inserts ...a6 before adopting the Steinitz shell.

PRIMARY PLAN

Keep the bishop useful, build d4, and punish passivity through piece improvement.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black prepares ...Nf6, ...Be7, and a later central challenge.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 d6 5. d4 Bd7 6. Nc3 Nf6

MEMORY RULE

Deferred Steinitz: preserve useful tension while Black remains cramped.

22. Decision Framework

Deferred Steinitz

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Bxc6 can release Black if the bishop pair becomes active.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

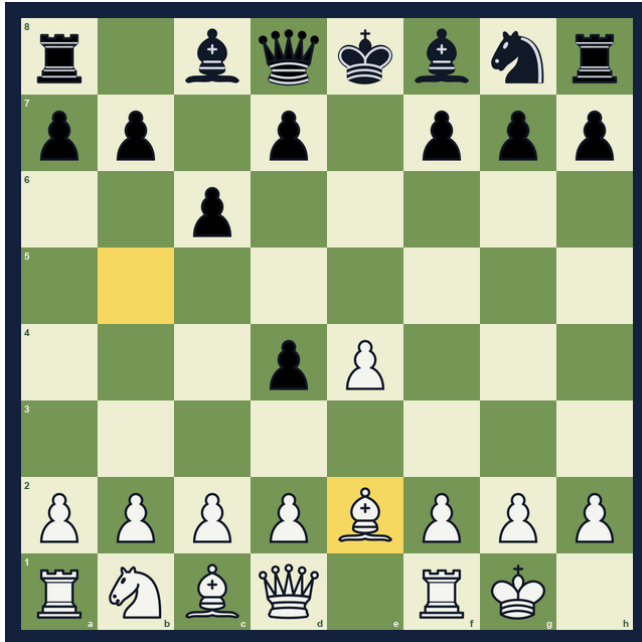
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Deferred Steinitz: preserve useful tension while Black remains cramped.

23. Bird Defense



07 - Early Black Sidelines

READ THE POSITION

Black centralizes the knight and accepts a structurally unusual recapture.

PRIMARY PLAN

Exchange only when the resulting d4 pawn can be blockaded and attacked.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black uses space and open lines from the advanced d-pawn.

REFERENCE LINE 1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 Nd4 4. Nxd4 exd4 5. O-O c6 6. Be2

MEMORY RULE

Bird: blockade first, attack second, collect last.

23. Decision Framework

Bird Defense

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Winning the d4 pawn too early can expose White's queen and lose development.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

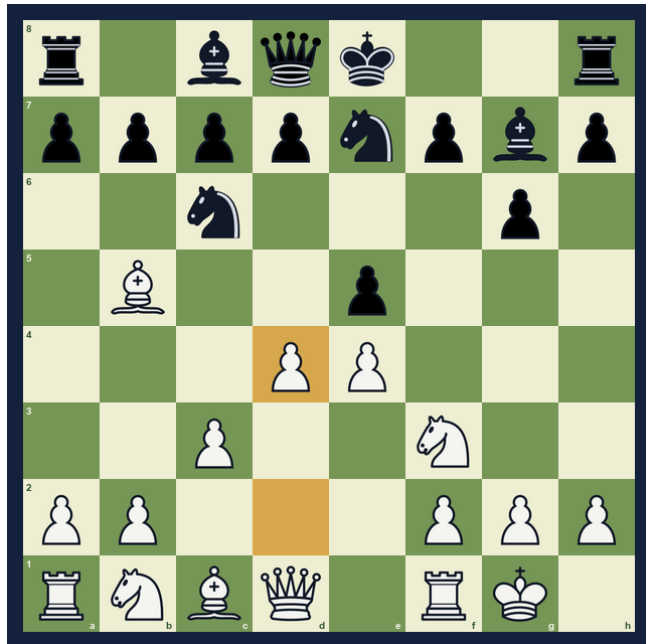
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Bird: blockade first, attack second, collect last.

24. Cozio Defense



07 - Early Black Sidelines

READ THE POSITION

Black develops the g8-knight to e7 and often prepares a kingside fianchetto.

PRIMARY PLAN

Occupy the center with d4 while Black's pieces compete for squares.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black challenges the center with ...exd4 and ...d5 or reroutes the knight.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 Nge7 4. O-O g6 5. c3 Bg7 6. d4

MEMORY RULE

Cozio: claim d4, then prove the center cannot be attacked.

24. Decision Framework

Cozio Defense

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	A large center is useful only when every pawn is defended.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

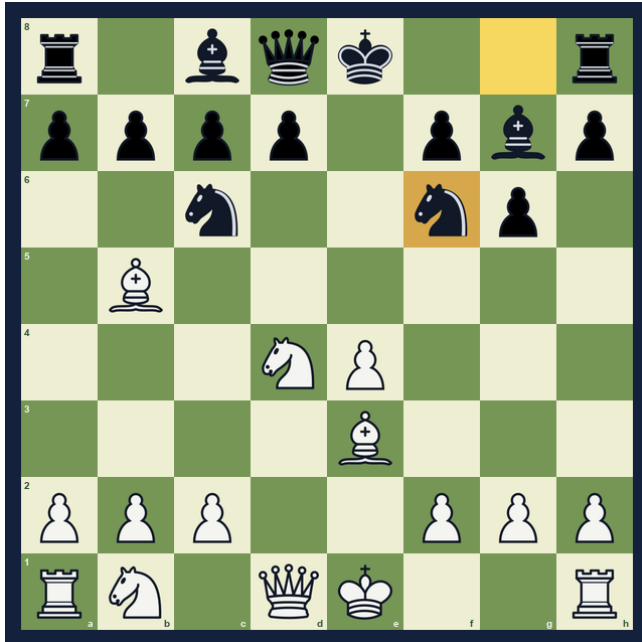
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Cozio: claim d4, then prove the center cannot be attacked.

25. Fianchetto Defense



07 - Early Black Sidelines

READ THE POSITION

Black immediately fianchettoes and pressures the long diagonal.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use central space and develop without allowing tactics against d4 or c3.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black attacks the center with ...Nf6, ...O-O, and ...Re8.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 g6 4. d4 exd4 5. Nxd4 Bg7 6. Be3 Nf6

MEMORY RULE

Fianchetto Ruy: occupy the center, then reinforce it.

25. Decision Framework

Fianchetto Defense

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	The g7-bishop can make an apparently protected d4 pawn tactically loose.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

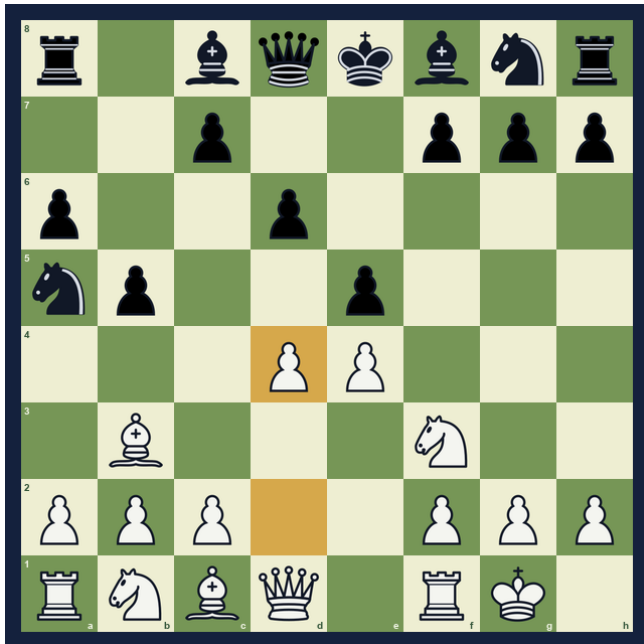
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Fianchetto Ruy: occupy the center, then reinforce it.

26. Norwegian Defense



07 - Early Black Sidelines

READ THE POSITION

Black spends time to exchange the Spanish bishop with ...Na5.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use the lead in development to open the center before Black consolidates.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black gains the bishop pair and queenside space if given time.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 b5 5. Bb3 Na5 6. O-O d6 7. d4

MEMORY RULE

Norwegian: open the center while Black's knight sits on the rim.

26. Decision Framework

Norwegian Defense

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Saving the bishop at any cost can waste the development advantage.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Norwegian: open the center while Black's knight sits on the rim.

27. Worrall Attack



08 - White Systems and Transpositions

READ THE POSITION

White supports e4 with the queen and keeps the rook flexible.

PRIMARY PLAN

Prepare Rd1 or Re1 according to the center and use c3-d4 under control.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black gains time on the bishop and seeks normal central counterplay.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Qe2 b5 7. Bb3 O-O 8. c3 d6

MEMORY RULE

Worrall: queen support is useful only when it improves the rook plan.

27. Decision Framework

Worrall Attack

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	The queen on e2 can obstruct a rook or become a target after ...Bg4.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Worrall: queen support is useful only when it improves the rook plan.

28. Center Attack



08 - White Systems and Transpositions

READ THE POSITION

White opens the center immediately and gains space with e5.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use the e5 wedge to gain tempi, but complete development before attacking.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black strikes with ...d5 and uses the e4-knight as a tactical outpost.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. d4 exd4 7. e5 Ne4 8. c3 d5

MEMORY RULE

Center Attack: gain space, then defend the base before chasing pieces.

28. Decision Framework

Center Attack

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	A space-gaining pawn can become overextended when its support disappears.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

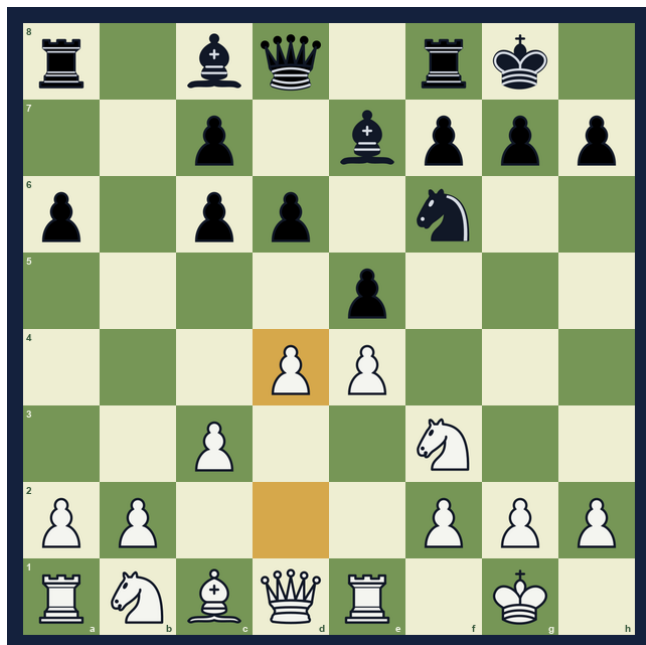
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Center Attack: gain space, then defend the base before chasing pieces.

29. Delayed Exchange



08 - White Systems and Transpositions

READ THE POSITION

White waits until Black commits before exchanging on c6 and changing the structure.

PRIMARY PLAN

Open the center when the damaged queenside can become a real target.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black uses the bishop pair and open b-file for activity.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 O-O 7. c3 d6 8. Bxc6 bxc6 9. d4

MEMORY RULE

Delayed Exchange: change the structure only when the center favors you.

29. Decision Framework

Delayed Exchange

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	The exchange is mistimed if Black's bishops gain open diagonals immediately.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Delayed Exchange: change the structure only when the center favors you.

30. Pilnik d3 System



08 - White Systems and Transpositions

READ THE POSITION

White keeps the center closed with d3 and delays the main d4 confrontation.

PRIMARY PLAN

Reroute the knight, prepare a4, and choose the right moment for d4.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black seeks ...Na5, ...c5, and ...d5 while White maneuvers.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6 8. c3 O-O 9. d3

MEMORY RULE

Pilnik: delay d4 to improve it, not to avoid it forever.

30. Decision Framework

Pilnik d3 System

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	A slow setup becomes passive if White never challenges the center.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Pilnik: delay d4 to improve it, not to avoid it forever.

Course Completion Test

Choose ten chapters at random. Rebuild each reference position, name both sides' plans, identify the critical break, and state the trade filter without reopening the chapter.

Score one point for the structure, one for your plan, one for counterplay, one for the break, and one for the memory rule. Forty out of fifty means the knowledge is usable; below forty means retrieval practice should continue.

FINAL PRINCIPLE

A course is complete when its ideas appear in your decisions, not when its pages have been read.